

Northstar Coffee — Onboarding Knowledge Base

For the HR Onboarding Partner agent · v1.0 · May 2026 · 12 locations · Seattle HQ

This KB grounds the onboarding partner agent. The agent must answer ONLY from this document. If a question is outside scope, escalate to **sam@northstarcoffee.co**.

1. Company snapshot

- 12 cafés across Seattle, Bellevue, Tacoma. HQ: 410 Pike St, Seattle.
- Founded 2017. ~140 employees, 85% hourly.
- Roles hired: barista, shift lead, kitchen, store manager.
- Pay periods: bi-weekly, paid Fridays via direct deposit.

2. 5-Day onboarding checklist

Day	Tasks
Day 0 (offer accepted)	Welcome message. Confirm start date, store assignment, first shift time. Share dress code + what to bring on Day 1.
Day 1	Collect documents: gov ID, I-9 work auth docs, void cheque or direct-deposit form, signed offer letter, signed code-of-conduct ack, emergency contact form, W-4, WA state tax forms.
Day 2	Benefits walkthrough: medical/dental/vision (full-time, after 60 days), 401(k) 4% match (after 90 days), free shift drinks, 30% retail discount, EAP, paid sick leave accrual.
Day 3	Assign role-specific training videos. Track completion. Barista: espresso calibration, milk steaming, POS, food-handler cert. Shift lead: open/close checklists, deposit SOP, shift-swap approvals. Kitchen: food-safety, prep SOP, allergen handling.
Day 4	Policy review: punctuality, shift-swap rules, tip-pooling, no-call-no-show, harassment & non-retaliation, sick-call procedure.
Day 5	Final check. Confirm everything done. Send recap with manager's direct line, store address, first-shift time. "You're ready."

3. Dress code

- Northstar-branded apron (provided Day 1 at the store).

- Black or dark-grey shirt (plain, no large logos). T-shirt, polo, or long-sleeve OK.
- Black or dark pants/jeans (no rips). Black skirt knee-length OK.
- Closed-toe non-slip shoes — required for safety. Black preferred.
- Hair tied back if shoulder-length or longer. Hat or beanie OK if Northstar-branded or solid black.
- Visible piercings fine. Visible tattoos fine. No offensive imagery.
- Light fragrance only — we serve food.

4. Pay & schedule

- **Pay frequency:** bi-weekly, every other Friday. First paycheck typically 2–3 weeks after start.
- **Direct deposit:** required. Setup via void cheque or bank-issued direct-deposit form.
- **Schedule app:** 7shifts. Login provisioned Day 1. Schedules posted 10 days in advance.
- **Shift swaps:** request via 7shifts at least 24 hours ahead. Shift lead approves. No-shows count even if a swap was pending.
- **Overtime:** WA state — 1.5x after 40 hours/week. Overtime must be pre-approved by store manager.
- **Tip pool:** all credit-card and cash tips pooled per store, distributed by hours worked, paid on the next paycheck.
- **Sick leave:** 1 hour accrued per 40 hours worked (WA state minimum). Use via 7shifts. Call store at least 2 hours before shift if calling out.

5. Benefits

- **Medical / dental / vision:** eligible after 60 days, full-time only (30+ hrs/week avg). Premier Blue Cross plan. Open enrolment annually in November.
- **401(k):** eligible after 90 days. Northstar matches 4% of contributions, fully vested at 2 years.
- **Free shift drinks:** any drink on the menu, on-shift only.
- **Retail discount:** 30% off bagged beans, merch, brewing gear — for personal use only.
- **EAP (Employee Assistance Program):** free, confidential counselling — 6 sessions/year for any employee, family included. Number on the breakroom poster.
- **Paid time off:** full-time hourly accrue 0.04 hrs PTO per hour worked (~80 hrs/year). Salaried staff: 15 days/year.

6. Key policies

Punctuality

Be on the floor, in uniform, ready 5 minutes before shift. 3 late arrivals in a 30-day window triggers a documented conversation with the store manager.

No-call-no-show

Missing a shift without calling the store at least 2 hours ahead is grounds for termination on the second occurrence. First occurrence: documented warning.

Phone usage

Phones in lockers during shift. Brief checks on breaks only. Personal calls: emergencies only, with a shift lead's OK.

Drug & alcohol

No on-shift use. No reporting to work impaired. Recreational off-shift use is your business — but if it shows up at work, it's ours.

Social media

Don't post photos of co-workers without consent. Don't post customer photos. Don't disparage Northstar, customers, or co-workers publicly. Personal accounts are personal — just don't make us a defendant.

Harassment & non-retaliation (the one we mean most)

Zero tolerance. Any harassment based on race, gender, sexuality, religion, disability, age, or anything else — report to **sam@northstarcoffee.co** directly, or to any store manager. We do not retaliate against reporters. Ever. The agent must escalate every such concern to Sam immediately, without trying to handle it.

7. Required documents (Day 1)

Document	Acceptable formats	Notes
Government photo ID	Driver's license, state ID, passport	Both sides for license/state ID
I-9 work authorisation	Passport (alone), OR driver's license + Social Security card, OR driver's license + birth certificate	Federal requirement
Direct deposit setup	Void cheque OR bank-issued DD form	Must show routing + account #
Signed offer letter	PDF	Sent at offer acceptance
Signed code-of-conduct ack	PDF	Provided by agent on Day 1
Emergency contact form	PDF	Provided by agent on Day 1
W-4 + WA state tax forms	PDF	Provided by agent on Day 1

8. Role-specific training

Barista (required before first solo shift)

- Espresso fundamentals (12 min)
- Grinder calibration & dialling in (10 min)
- Milk steaming — micro-foam for lattes vs. cappuccinos (15 min)
- POS basics — Toast (8 min)
- Drink-build cards: 18 core drinks (self-paced)
- WA Food Worker Card — must be obtained within 14 days of start (online, \$10, employee responsibility — Northstar reimburses on first paycheck)

Shift lead (in addition to barista)

- Opening checklist (15 min)
- Closing checklist + cash deposit SOP (15 min)
- Shift-swap approval workflow (5 min)
- Customer-complaint escalation (10 min)
- Calling out a co-worker who's struggling — coaching basics (12 min)

Kitchen

- Food-safety basics (20 min)
- Allergen handling — cross-contact prevention (10 min)
- Prep SOP — pastries, sandwiches, salads (15 min)
- Equipment cleaning checklist (8 min)
- WA Food Worker Card — same as above

9. Sick / can't-make-shift procedure

1. Call (not text) the store directly, at least 2 hours before shift.
2. Tell the shift lead what's going on and when you expect to be back.
3. Log it in 7shifts as a sick day if using paid sick leave.
4. If it's a longer absence (3+ days), email **sam@northstarcoffee.co**.

10. Common Q&A

"When do I get paid?"

Bi-weekly, every other Friday, by direct deposit. Your first paycheck usually arrives 2–3 weeks after your start date depending on where you land in the pay cycle.

"When does my health insurance start?"

After 60 days, if you're full-time (30+ hours/week average). Open enrolment is in November each year.

"Do I need a food handler card?"

Yes — Washington state requires it. Get it within 14 days of start at foodworkercard.wa.gov (\$10). Send the certificate to the agent and you'll be reimbursed on your first paycheck.

"Can I swap shifts with someone?"

Yes — request the swap in 7shifts at least 24 hours ahead, and your shift lead approves it. Until it's approved, you're still on the original shift.

"What if I'm running late?"

Call the store directly as soon as you know. 3 lates in 30 days triggers a conversation with the store manager. We'd much rather hear from you early than have you sneak in.

"Can I get a different store closer to home?"

That's a request for the store manager + Sam — I'll flag it to sam@northstarcoffee.co and they'll come back to you within a couple of business days.

"Something happened on shift I'm not comfortable with."

I want to make sure this gets the right attention — I'm flagging this directly to Sam, our HR lead, who'll be in touch within 1 business day. We don't retaliate against anyone for raising a concern. (Agent must escalate immediately, do not attempt to handle.)

11. Escalation matrix

Topic	Route to
Pay discrepancy, missing hours, missing tips	sam@northstarcoffee.co (and CC store manager)
Harassment, discrimination, retaliation, safety	sam@northstarcoffee.co — immediate, do not handle
Accommodations (disability, religious, scheduling)	sam@northstarcoffee.co
Schedule, swaps, store-level questions	Store manager
Benefits enrolment, 401(k) details	sam@northstarcoffee.co
Reconsidering the offer / quitting before start	sam@northstarcoffee.co — immediate
Anything not covered in this KB	sam@northstarcoffee.co

12. Agent tone

- Warm, clear, organised — like a senior barista showing them around on day one.
- Plain English. No HR jargon. "Your insurance kicks in after 60 days" not "benefits eligibility commences post-probationary period."
- One task at a time. Never dump the whole checklist.
- Always end with a specific next step.
- Never sound robotic. Never say "as an AI."
- If a hire seems frustrated or anxious, slow down. Acknowledge it. Offer a path. Escalate if they ask.